would run in slowly and bowl him an unexpected bouncer, hoping to induce a top edge. In doing so, I pulled a muscle in my side. The pain was surprisingly acute and I had to go to the hospital during the lunch break to have three cortisone injections. Even when I rejoined the team at the ground I was still extremely sore and found it difficult to run or bend.

The second Test started on 2 January 1997, so there were only a few days for the team to recover and regroup. It was never going to be enough to cope with a really good South African side. In Allan Donald and Shaun Pollock, the South Africans had two of the best fast bowlers in the world, and they complemented each other beautifully in home conditions. While Donald was fast, Pollock could swing the ball both ways and was a master of his craft. Nevertheless, we did manage to show some signs of competitiveness in Cape Town and both Azhar and I got hundreds in the first innings.

I went in to bat towards the end of the second day and was unbeaten on one at the end of play, with the team score on 29–3. The following morning I was practising against throw-downs ahead of the game and tried shuffling back and across to a few of the balls. It felt really good and I even timed the balls well. Something in me said that I should employ the back-and-across movement that day. I did so and found that, even when the bowlers were bowling at close to 150 kph, I still had plenty of time. Normally I would stand just outside my leg stump while taking guard, but at Cape Town I was standing a good few inches outside to accommodate the shuffle. I ended up making 169. I always felt that I needed to be comfortable in my head before I focused on technique. If I wasn't comfortable to start with, fretting about technique would not do much for my batting.

The other incident I remember from the Cape Town Test and which I thoroughly enjoyed involved Allan Donald and the Indian medium-fast bowler Dodda Ganesh. Donald, who was in top form in that series, had no patience with lower-order batsmen and was frustrated to see Ganesh hanging around. As Dodda faced his onslaught fearlessly, Allan started mouthing words at him. For three consecutive deliveries Dodda was all over the place but luckily for him did not lose his wicket. At the end of the over Allan went up to Dodda and told him what he thought of him in no uncertain terms. Dodda's face remained impassive.